ENGLISH C2 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Advanced clefts and pseudo-clefts

Manipulate it-clefts, reversed pseudo-clefts and all-clefts to contrast assumptions and create precise focus structures. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use advanced clefts and pseudo-clefts to identify exactly which constituent corrects, narrows or completes a proposition while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Manipulate it-clefts, reversed pseudo-clefts and all-clefts to contrast assumptions and create precise focus structures.

MODEL

What the data cannot establish is why the effect occurred.

it + be + focus + relative clause | wh-clause + be + focus | focus + be + wh-clause

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main advanced clefts and pseudo-clefts patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses identify exactly which constituent corrects, narrows or completes a proposition.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in argument, explanation, rhetoric and carefully managed conversation.

Build meaning before form

Manipulate it-clefts, reversed pseudo-clefts and all-clefts to contrast assumptions and create precise focus structures.

What advanced clefts and pseudo-clefts communicates

Manipulate it-clefts, reversed pseudo-clefts and all-clefts to contrast assumptions and create precise focus structures.

The central purpose is to identify exactly which constituent corrects, narrows or completes a proposition. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

It was the timing, not the method, that caused concern.	a constituent contrasted against an alternative assumption
What the data cannot establish is why the effect occurred.	a gap or issue introduced before its focused completion
A complete reassessment is what the situation now requires.	the focused answer presented before the identifying clause

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: it + be + focus + relative clause | wh-clause + be + focus | focus + be + wh-clause. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model “What the data cannot establish is why the effect occurred.” shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
Contrastive it-cleft	it + be + focus + who/that clause	It was the timing, not the method, that caused concern.
Pseudo-cleft	wh-clause + be + focus	What the data cannot establish is why the effect occurred.
Reversed pseudo-cleft	focus + be + wh-clause	A complete reassessment is what the situation now requires.

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
a constituent contrasted against an alternative assumption	Contrastive it-cleft
a gap or issue introduced before its focused completion	Pseudo-cleft
the focused answer presented before the identifying clause	Reversed pseudo-cleft

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in argument, explanation, rhetoric and carefully managed conversation. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01	02	03	04	05	06	07	08	09	10
it	be	focus	relative clause	wh-clause	be	focus	focus	be	wh-clause

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: identify exactly which constituent corrects, narrows or completes a proposition.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits argument, explanation, rhetoric and carefully managed conversation.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
Contrastive it-cleft	it + be + focus + who/that clause	It was the timing, not the method, that caused concern.
Pseudo-cleft	wh-clause + be + focus	What the data cannot establish is why the effect occurred.
Reversed pseudo-cleft	focus + be + wh-clause	A complete reassessment is what the situation now requires.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

It was the timing, not the method, that caused concern.	a constituent contrasted against an alternative assumption
What the data cannot establish is why the effect occurred.	a gap or issue introduced before its focused completion
A complete reassessment is what the situation now requires.	the focused answer presented before the identifying clause

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not use a cleft when no genuine contrast or correction exists.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Keep number agreement natural when the wh-clause and focus differ in form.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not reverse a pseudo-cleft if the resulting theme disrupts discourse flow.

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a constituent contrasted against an alternative assumption?

OPTIONS It was the timing, not the method, that caused concern. · What the data cannot establish is why the effect occurred. · A complete reassessment is what the situation now requires.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a gap or issue introduced before its focused completion?

OPTIONS What the data cannot establish is why the effect occurred. · A complete reassessment is what the situation now requires. · It was the timing, not the method, that caused concern.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: the focused answer presented before the identifying clause?

OPTIONS A complete reassessment is what the situation now requires. · It was the timing, not the method, that caused concern. · What the data cannot establish is why the effect occurred.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “It was the timing, not the method, that caused concern.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a constituent contrasted against an alternative assumption · a gap or issue introduced before its focused completion · the focused answer presented before the identifying clause

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “What the data cannot establish is why the effect occurred.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a gap or issue introduced before its focused completion · the focused answer presented before the identifying clause · a constituent contrasted against an alternative assumption

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “A complete reassessment is what the situation now requires.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS the focused answer presented before the identifying clause · a constituent contrasted against an alternative assumption · a gap or issue introduced before its focused completion

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

"It was the timing, not the method, that caused concern." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Contrastive it-cleft / Pseudo-cleft / Reversed pseudo-cleft · Gap 2: a constituent contrasted against an alternative assumption / a gap or issue introduced before its focused completion / the focused answer presented before the identifying clause

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

"What the data cannot establish is why the effect occurred." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Pseudo-cleft / Reversed pseudo-cleft / Contrastive it-cleft · Gap 2: a gap or issue introduced before its focused completion / the focused answer presented before the identifying clause / a constituent contrasted against an alternative assumption

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

"A complete reassessment is what the situation now requires." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Reversed pseudo-cleft / Contrastive it-cleft / Pseudo-cleft · Gap 2: the focused answer presented before the identifying clause / a constituent contrasted against an alternative assumption / a gap or issue introduced before its focused completion

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses a constituent contrasted against an alternative assumption: _____. Choose the model that expresses a gap or issue introduced before its focused completion: _____. Choose the model that expresses the focused answer presented before the identifying clause: _____. Choose the model built with it + be + focus + who/that clause: _____. Choose the model built with wh-clause + be + focus: _____. Choose the model built with focus + be + wh-clause: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

A complete reassessment is what the situation now requires. · It was the timing, not the method, that caused concern. · What the data cannot establish is why the effect occurred.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

_____, not the method, that caused concern. _____ is why the effect occurred. _____ the situation now requires. State the full structural pattern for Contrastive it-cleft: _____. State the full structural pattern for Pseudo-cleft: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “The timing caused concern, not the method.” using the Contrastive it-cleft pattern to express a constituent contrasted against an alternative assumption.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “The data cannot establish the cause of the effect.” using the Pseudo-cleft pattern to express a gap or issue introduced before its focused completion.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “The situation now requires a complete reassessment.” using the Reversed pseudo-cleft pattern to express the focused answer presented before the identifying clause.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “The timing caused concern, not the method.” using the Contrastive it-cleft pattern to express a constituent contrasted against an alternative assumption.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Contrastive it-cleft to express a constituent contrasted against an alternative assumption, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Pseudo-cleft to express a gap or issue introduced before its focused completion, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Reversed pseudo-cleft to express the focused answer presented before the identifying clause, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

It was the timing, not the method, that caused concern.

Contrastive it-cleft is the best match because a constituent contrasted against an alternative assumption.

A2

What the data cannot establish is why the effect occurred.

Pseudo-cleft is the best match because a gap or issue introduced before its focused completion.

A3

A complete reassessment is what the situation now requires.

Reversed pseudo-cleft is the best match because the focused answer presented before the identifying clause.

A4

a constituent contrasted against an alternative assumption

The Contrastive it-cleft pattern communicates a constituent contrasted against an alternative assumption.

A5

a gap or issue introduced before its focused completion

The Pseudo-cleft pattern communicates a gap or issue introduced before its focused completion.

A6

the focused answer presented before the identifying clause

The Reversed pseudo-cleft pattern communicates the focused answer presented before the identifying clause.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

Contrastive it-cleft / a constituent contrasted against an alternative assumption

The structure belongs to the Contrastive it-cleft pattern. Its communicative purpose is a constituent contrasted against an alternative assumption.

B2

Pseudo-cleft / a gap or issue introduced before its focused completion

The structure belongs to the Pseudo-cleft pattern. Its communicative purpose is a gap or issue introduced before its focused completion.

B3

Reversed pseudo-cleft / the focused answer presented before the identifying clause

The structure belongs to the Reversed pseudo-cleft pattern. Its communicative purpose is the focused answer presented before the identifying clause.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

It was the timing, not the method, that caused concern.

Contrastive it-cleft: it + be + focus + who/that clause.

C2

What the data cannot establish is why the effect occurred.

Pseudo-cleft: wh-clause + be + focus.

C3

A complete reassessment is what the situation now requires.

Reversed pseudo-cleft: focus + be + wh-clause.

C4

It was the timing, not the method, that caused concern.

Contrastive it-cleft: it + be + focus + who/that clause.

C5

What the data cannot establish is why the effect occurred.

Pseudo-cleft: wh-clause + be + focus.

C6

A complete reassessment is what the situation now requires.

Reversed pseudo-cleft: focus + be + wh-clause.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

It was the timing

Contrastive it-cleft requires “It was the timing” in this model. it + be + focus + who/that clause.

D2

What the data cannot establish

Pseudo-cleft requires “What the data cannot establish” in this model. wh-clause + be + focus.

D3

A complete reassessment is what

Reversed pseudo-cleft requires “A complete reassessment is what” in this model. focus + be + wh-clause.

D4

it + be + focus + who/that clause

Contrastive it-cleft is built as it + be + focus + who/that clause.

D5

wh-clause + be + focus

Pseudo-cleft is built as wh-clause + be + focus.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

It was the timing, not the method, that caused concern.

it + be + focus + who/that clause. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended contrastive it-cleft effect.

E2

What the data cannot establish is why the effect occurred.

wh-clause + be + focus. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended pseudo-cleft effect.

E3

A complete reassessment is what the situation now requires.

focus + be + wh-clause. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended reversed pseudo-cleft effect.

E4

It was the timing, not the method, that caused concern.

it + be + focus + who/that clause. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended contrastive it-cleft effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

It was the timing, not the method, that caused concern. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses it + be + focus + who/that clause accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

What the data cannot establish is why the effect occurred. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses wh-clause + be + focus accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

A complete reassessment is what the situation now requires. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses focus + be + wh-clause accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____